Travel Tutorial - Added Features

What was added, how to use it, and how it works. Updated 10 October 2026.

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1. Voice input (chat)

- **What:** A mic button next to the message box. You speak and your words appear in the box. Nothing sends until you press Send.
- **How to use:** Click the mic, speak, click again to stop.
- **How it works:** The browser's built-in speech recognition, so there is no API key or cost. It works in Chrome and Edge; the button is hidden in other browsers.

2. Voice replies (read aloud)

- **What:** The assistant can speak its answers.
- **How to use:** A speaker icon on every reply plays that one. "Read aloud: On/Off" speaks each new reply automatically, and the setting is remembered.
- **How it works:** Markdown is stripped first, so it never says "asterisk" or reads table pipes. Speech is split into sentence-sized pieces because Chrome cuts off long utterances.

3. Maps and weather for any place

- **What:** Destinations outside the 15 curated cities, like Ooty, now get a map, weather and real hotel search.
- **How it works:** Curated coordinates are used first, so Goa stays correct. Otherwise it falls back to Open-Meteo's free place lookup.

4. Hidden Gems Mode

- **What:** A toggle that steers away from the famous, crowded spots.
- **How to use:** "Hidden gems: On/Off" at the top of the chat. It is saved per chat.
- **How it works:** The AI tags places Quiet, Moderate or Busy, with the best time to avoid crowds. For the curated cities, saved itineraries also put quieter places first. Crowd levels are estimates, not live data.

5. Mood Match

- **What:** Discover destinations from a feeling, such as "cozy mountains, mist and chai".
- **How to use:** Open the Mood tab. Type or speak a vibe, get destination cards, then press "Plan this trip" to open a new chat with the request filled in.
- **How it works:** The AI reads the mood. If it fails, a keyword matcher takes over.

6. Travel Personality Quiz

- **What:** Five questions that name your traveler type, such as "Slow Wanderer", and fill in your preferences.
- **How to use:** "Take the quiz" on the Profile page.
- **How it works:** The result is saved as your travel style, interests and food preference, and the AI applies it to every new plan.

7. What-If simulator

- **What:** Try a change and see its effect before committing.
- **How to use:** "What if..." on a trip. Options: budget +/-20%, add or remove a day, or "it rains on day N".
- **How it works:** Shows before and after, including cost. Nothing changes until you press Apply. Rain swaps outdoor activities for indoor ones.

8. Live Today Mode

- **What:** A page for the day of the trip.
- **How to use:** "Today mode" on a trip. Set the start date and it highlights what is happening Now and Next. Say or tap "I'm running an hour late" and the rest of the day shifts. "What's next?" is answered aloud.

9. Group Voting

- **What:** Friends vote on the plan from the shared link.
- **How to use:** Share the trip. Each person enters a name and votes thumbs up or down on every activity, with no account needed. The owner sees the verdicts under "See group votes" and can remove everything voted down in one click.
- **How it works:** Each browser gets a random private ID, so one person gets one vote per activity and can change it. There is a limit of 30 voters per trip, plus rate limiting against abuse.

Behind the scenes

- A new database table, **activity_votes**, stores the group votes.
- 127 unit tests and 2 end-to-end tests pass; everything is committed and pushed to GitHub.
- Voting was only partly verified live because the database was slow. The "remove voted-down" step is covered by unit tests only.